TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Use of Communication by Management

How managers actually spend communication — the tools of the trade: orders and instructions, meetings, reports, notices, consultation and the management information system.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 5 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. Communication as the manager’s toolkit

Topic 4 established that managers communicate most of the day. This topic names the instruments. Each management function draws its own communication tools:

FUNCTION	COMMUNICATION IT USES
Planning	Collecting information upward and outward; issuing objectives, budgets and schedules downward in writing
Organising	Defining and publishing roles, authority and procedures — the organisation chart and the job description are communication documents
Directing	Orders and instructions, briefings, day-to-day oral guidance on the floor
Controlling	Reports and returns flowing upward against standards; variance explanations; corrective instructions flowing back down
Coordinating	Meetings, liaison roles, shared schedules and cross-department correspondence

2. Orders and instructions: the downward instruments

An **order** is a directive from a superior requiring action; good orders — written ones especially — observe the classic rules: they are **clear** (one interpretation possible), **complete** (what, how much, by when, to what standard), **feasible** (within the receiver’s capacity and authority), **addressed** (a named person owns them), and **followed up** (feedback closes the loop). Instructions differ from orders in teaching the method as well as naming the task; shop-floor instruction is management’s most repeated act of communication and the one training programmes formalise (job instruction technique: prepare, present, try out, follow up).

3. Meetings: the group instrument

Management runs on meetings: production meetings, quality reviews, buyer conferences. A meeting is itself a communication system with known engineering — an **agenda** circulated in advance (the meeting's encoding), a chair controlling the channel, **minutes** recording decisions and owners (its permanent record — the meeting otherwise evaporates like speech, Topic 3), and action points feeding the control loop. Meetings also carry the informal functions that memos cannot: commitment made in public, disagreement surfaced while it is still small, and the non-verbal reading of a room.

4. Written instruments: reports, memos, notices

- **Reports** — the upward instrument par excellence (production, quality, inspection reports): the material of Topics 9–10 of this course.
- **Memoranda (memos)** — the internal letter: short, single-subject communications within the organisation, filed as records.
- **Notices and circulars** — the downward mass instruments: policies, holidays, safety rules; posted on notice boards and, in the modern mill, pushed through internal messaging groups — chosen when the same permanent message must reach everyone identically.
- **Manuals and standing orders** — communication stored against need: procedures written once, consulted always.

5. Consultation and the upward instruments

Management also communicates *to listen*: consultation before decisions that affect the workforce (joint consultation committees), suggestion schemes, grievance procedures, exit interviews, and the open door. These are not kindnesses bolted onto management; they are its sensory system — the channels through which it learns what the downward instruments cannot tell it: how orders actually landed, where the procedure fails in practice, which rumour needs an answer. Modern practice adds the **management information system (MIS)**: the formal, often computerised pipeline converting floor data (production, quality, inventory) into the summaries on which managers decide — communication by design rather than by habit.

6. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Order	A superior's directive requiring a specified action.
Agenda	The list of business for a meeting, circulated beforehand.
Minutes	The written record of a meeting's attendance, decisions and action owners.

Memorandum (memo)	A short internal written communication within an organisation.
Circular	A notice sent identically to many recipients.
Consultation	Seeking the views of those affected before a decision is taken.
MIS	Management information system — the formal pipeline turning operating data into decision summaries.

7. Key points and summary

- Every management function has its communication tools: planning informs, organising publishes, directing orders, controlling reports, coordinating meets.
- Good orders are clear, complete, feasible, addressed and followed up; meetings are engineered with agenda, chair and minutes; written instruments (reports, memos, circulars, manuals) give communication memory.
- Consultation and grievance channels are management's listening system, and the MIS is the same idea formalised into data pipelines.

8. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Match each managerial need to its best instrument: (a) teach a new machine procedure to forty operators; (b) settle a scheduling conflict between two sections; (c) record a decision taken by five managers; (d) warn all shifts of a new safety rule.
2. Judge this order against the five rules of §2: "Someone should check the dye store sometime this week." Rewrite it to pass.
3. Why do minutes matter, in terms of Topic 3's classification of communication?
4. Distinguish a memo from a circular by audience and purpose.
5. "Consultation is management's sensory system." Explain, naming two consultation instruments and what each senses.
6. What does an MIS add beyond the traditional report system?
7. A production meeting keeps ending without clear actions. Diagnose it with §3's engineering and prescribe the fixes.

Answer key

1. (a) Written instructions/manual plus a demonstration briefing — method must be identical for all and kept for reference. (b) A meeting of the two section heads (horizontal coordination). (c) Minutes.

(d) A circular/notice to every shift (identical permanent message), backed by supervisors' briefings.

2. It fails all five: unclear (check — how, against what?), incomplete (no quantity, standard or deadline beyond "sometime"), unaddressed ("someone" owns nothing), follow-up unspecified. Rewrite: "Mr. Karim (dye-store in-charge) will verify the stock of reactive dyes against the register and report shortages to me in writing by Wednesday 12:00."
3. Speech is oral communication — fast but leaving no record and distorting on relay. Minutes convert the meeting's outcomes into written communication: permanent, provable, distributable to the absent.
4. A memo addresses a specific person or small group inside the organisation about one internal matter; a circular carries one identical message to many recipients at once.
5. Downward channels can only report what management asks; consultation hears what it did not ask about. Suggestion schemes sense floor-level improvement ideas; grievance procedures sense discontent while it is still individual and repairable.
6. Regularity, speed and aggregation: data is captured as generated, summarised automatically to each level's need, and comparable across periods — reports by request become information by system.
7. Missing engineering: no agenda circulated (members arrive unprepared), no disciplined chairing (channel uncontrolled), and therefore decisions dissolve. Fixes: agenda with owners in advance, chair enforcing decisions and action points, minutes issued within a day naming owner and date for each action.
